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Early returns inconclusive in Southern California elections

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SACRAMENTO, Calif. (AP) — Preliminary returns Tuesday night from Southern California, where residents were voting for new representatives in the state Legislature, were inconclusive shortly after polls closed.

Less than 11 percent of precincts had reported results as of 9 p.m. All the early returns came from vote-by-mail ballots.

Luz Rivas had taken the lead in the race to replace former Assemblyman Raul Bocanegra with just 10 percent of precincts reporting. Less than 2 percent of precincts had reported returns in the elections to replace former Assemblymen Matt Dababneh and Sebastian Ridley-Thomas.

The Tuesday election is expected to determine which candidates will advance to the next round of voting for the three open Assembly seats.

If any candidate wins more than half of votes Tuesday, they win outright. Otherwise the top-two finishers in each race advance to a June runoff.

Ballots were still being counted Tuesday night. The election results are expected to be certified April 12, according to Los Angeles County.

Candidates are vying to replace the three male lawmakers who resigned last year. Bocanegra and Dababneh quit amid sexual harassment allegations. Ridley-Thomas left citing health problems. Their departures could make room for more women in the Legislature, where nearly 80 percent of lawmakers are men.

An early sampling of randomly selected precincts indicated turnout was between 8 and 11 percent in all three districts, the Los Angeles County registrar's office said on Twitter.

Almost 800,000 people are registered to vote in the three districts and Democrats outnumber Republicans in all three.

The 45th District in the southwest San Fernando Valley has lacked representation in the Assembly since Jan. 1, when Dababneh resigned.

A lobbyist said he pushed her into a bathroom during a social event in Las Vegas and masturbated in front of her, which he denies.

Jesse Gabriel, a constitutional rights attorney, and Tricia Robbins Kasson, a Los Angeles City Council aide, are the leading fundraisers in the race to replace him.

Democrats Ankur Patel, Daniel Brin, Jeff Bornstein and Ray Bishop are also running. Dennis Zine, a no-party-preference candidate, also appeared on the ballot but had announced he wasn't campaigning.

The only Republican running in the district is 18-year-old Justin Clark, a college student who works part-time in an ice cream shop.

Bocanegra resigned his seat in the 39th District after multiple women accused him of unwanted groping and kissing. He has denied committing any crimes against the women.

His district, which encompasses the northeast area of the San Fernando Valley, has lacked representation since November.

Rivas, a nonprofit founder and engineer, and Antonio Sanchez, a workforce development director, have raised the most money in their bids to replace Bocanegra.

Former Assemblywoman Patty Lopez is also running for the seat, along with three other Democrats — Bonnie Corwin, Yolanda Anguiano and Patrea Patrick. Ricardo Benitez is the only Republican in the race.

Residents of the 54th District, which includes the University of California, Los Angeles campus and Culver City, also voted Tuesday.

Tepring Piquado, a neuroscientist, and Sydney Kamlager, a Los Angeles Community College District trustee, are the leading fundraisers in the race to replace Ridley-Thomas, who resigned in December. Republican Glen Ratcliff and Democrat Grayson Pangilinan are also running for the seat.

The elections are estimated to cost $1.6 million, according to Los Angeles County, which includes all three districts, except for a tiny sliver of the 45th District in Ventura County.

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